

Tube video,” says the former chef with a background in mixology.

After sharing his creations with family and friends and getting positive feedback at farmers’ markets, he decided to turn it into a business. Pascati is India’s first USDA Organic and Fair Trade Compliant chocolate brand. Today the brand is available at exclusive organic food stores in most metro cities and also places like Goa, Ahmedabad and Rishikesh. While most sales come from offline, it is also ordered online on their website. A large chunk

powder from Kerala. Then there is blueberry walnut which has blueberry natural oil and walnuts from Kashmir. Another popular flavour is raspberry hibiscus. “I was a bartender earlier where one is always experimenting with what flavour profile works best with which particular cocktail. So the raspberry-hibiscus was actually inspired by one of the cocktails I created,” he smiles.

Ashar says none of his chocolates have any kind of emulsifiers or preservatives and he makes around 8,000 bars a month in the

to be India’s first zero-waste chocolate. From using completely recyclable materials for packaging to getting it designed by an organisation for the differently-abled, Kocoatrait is a chocolate for a conscious consumer. “Cacao is a very unsustainable raw material and there is no running away from that. So we wanted to do more to ensure that the chocolate did not harm the planet,” says Chordia who is India’s first certified cacao and chocolate taster.

The couple also runs Cocoashala, a training and incubation centre



SUSTAINABILITY IS A BIG FACTOR FOR MOST INDIAN CRAFT CHOCOLATE MAKERS, DISTINGUISHING THEM FROM THE LARGER INDUSTRIAL PLAYERS

of their business comes from corporate gifting where they customise the chocolate and the packaging. Ashar primarily works with cacao from Kerala which is fruity and robust in nature. He does interesting flavours like orange, cinnamon and hazelnut, which uses natural orange oil and is dusted with cinnamon

off season and between 24,000 and 30,000 in the peak season. Ashar believes in sustainability and two-thirds of his power requirement comes from solar energy.

For Chennai-based couple Poonam and L. Nitin Chordia, sustainability is the cornerstone of their venture Kocoatrait, which is aiming

for those wanting to get into the craft chocolate business. They have trained around 137 people till now.

Kocoatrait offers some very interesting flavours. “Our idea is simple: we don’t want to make anything that someone else is already making,” says Chordia. So you get chocolates that are flavoured with jasmine or green chilli or even masala chai!

Go ahead and indulge in Indian craft chocolates knowing that they are sustainable and organic. After all, no one can eat just one. **BT**

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